

Instructor Guide — Course 16, Lesson 1

Lesson Metadata

Field	Detail
Path	Digital Independence Path
Course	16 — Build Your Professional Identity
Lesson	1 of Course 16
Title	What Professional Identity Means in the Digital Age
Age range	15–18
Format	Live, instructor-led, screen-share video class
Duration	~60 minutes
Difficulty	Introductory (conceptual, low technical load)
Prerequisites	None. Students should have at least one completed Lumexa project (any course) to reference, but it is not required to complete this lesson.
Tools used this lesson	A web browser (for the live demo), Google Docs (for the worksheet)
Tools used later in Course 16	HTML, CSS, Vercel, Canva, GitHub, Google Docs

Course 16 progression reminder: this course sits inside the larger Digital Independence Path sequence of **Identity** → **Services** → **Clients** → **Professional Presence** → **Opportunities**. Lesson 1 is the "Identity" foundation — nothing here is about freelance platforms, job boards, or client acquisition yet. Keep the lesson focused on self-understanding and evidence, not on "getting hired."

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to: 1. Define "professional identity" and "digital reputation" in their own words. 2. Explain the difference between a *claim* ("I'm good at coding") and *evidence* ("here is a working project I built"). 3. Audit their own current online footprint at a basic level, safely and privately. 4. Identify at least three pieces of real evidence they already have from Lumexa or other work. 5. Articulate one personal goal for what they want their professional identity to communicate by the end of Course 16.

Deliverables

- Completed **Digital Identity Audit** worksheet (submitted via Google Docs link or upload, per your classroom's submission method).
- Verbal or chat participation in the discussion segment.

Skills Practiced

- Self-assessment and reflection
- Basic online research / search literacy
- Distinguishing claims from evidence
- Early-stage personal branding thinking (not design yet — that's a later lesson)

Portfolio Connection

This lesson does not produce a portfolio artifact directly, but the worksheet output (their "3 things I want people to know" and "3 pieces of evidence") becomes the raw material for Lesson 2+ of this course, where students start building the actual portfolio site, brand kit, and case studies. Tell students explicitly: *"Nothing you write today is throwaway — you'll reuse this worksheet in the next lesson."*

Instructor Prep Checklist

- [] Read this guide fully and skim the Student Lesson and Worksheet files before class.
- [] Have a browser window ready for the live "search result walkthrough" demo, using the **fictional persona** described below (never search a real student's name live).
- [] Have the Worksheet (Google Doc or PDF) ready to share/link with students at the start of class.
- [] Prepare your screen share so the demo search results are pre-loaded or bookmarked — do not fumble live searches on stage.
- [] Review the "Common Misconceptions" and "Discussion Questions" sections so you're ready to redirect, not lecture.
- [] Have at least one real (with permission) or fictional example of a student project from Lumexa to point to as "this counts as evidence."
- [] Confirm your classroom's policy for how students submit the worksheet (Google Doc share, LMS upload, etc.) and state it clearly at the end of class.
- [] Note which students are new to Lumexa (no prior projects yet) — you'll need the "no footprint yet" alternative activity ready for them.

Required Files / Links

- [Student_Lesson.md](#) — share the "what you'll learn" and glossary sections on-screen as needed.
- [Worksheet.md](#) — convert to your platform's fillable format (Google Doc template, PDF form, or LMS form) before class; students fill this in live during the activity segment.

- A blank/incognito browser tab for the live demo (so autocomplete/history doesn't leak).

Suggested Teaching Sequence (60 minutes)

Time	Segment	What happens
0:00–0:05	Welcome & framing	Greet students, state the goal of the lesson and how it connects to the rest of Course 16 and the Digital Independence Path.
0:05–0:15	Concept intro: Professional Identity & Digital Reputation	Explain both terms using the analogies below. Check for understanding with a quick poll/thumbs-up.
0:15–0:20	Claims vs. Evidence	Explain the distinction with concrete examples pulled from coding contexts.
0:20–0:35	Live Demo: Search Result Walkthrough	Walk through the fictional persona's search results together, narrating what a stranger would conclude.
0:35–0:40	Discussion Questions	Pose 2–3 discussion questions, take verbal or chat answers.
0:40–0:55	In-Class Activity: Digital Identity Audit	Students fill in the worksheet privately (self-paced, instructor circulates / monitors chat for questions).
0:55–0:60	Wrap-up & submission instructions	Recap key terms, preview Lesson 2, confirm how/when to submit the worksheet.

Instructor Talking Points

What is "professional identity"?

Say something like:

"Your professional identity is the answer to the question: *if someone who's never met you looked at what you've made, what would they think you're capable of?* It's not about being fake or 'corporate' — it's about making the real skills you already have visible and easy to trust."

Analogy for teens: Compare it to a gaming profile or a Discord server reputation. *"You know how in a game, your rank, your stats, and your match history tell other players what you can actually do — not what you say you can do? Professional identity works the same way, except the 'game' is your coding skill, and the 'stats' are your real projects."*

What is "digital reputation"?

"Digital reputation is what's already out there about you online, whether you built it on purpose or not. It's the difference between the identity you're actively building and the scattered, accidental trail you've left without thinking about it — old social posts, a school project on GitHub nobody documented, a comment on a forum from three years ago."

Analogy: *"It's like your search history, except it's other people's search history about you."*

Important: for students under 16 or with little to no online presence, reassure them this is completely normal — the point of the lesson is to start building this on purpose, not to judge them for not having one yet.

Framing "professional" correctly (counter the "fake/corporate" misconception early)

"Professional doesn't mean stiff, boring, or pretending to be a 40-year-old. It means: clear, honest, and backed by evidence. A 16-year-old's professional identity should still sound like a 16-year-old — just one who can prove what they say."

Live Demo Instructions: The Search Result Walkthrough

Do not search a real student's name live. Use a prepared, clearly-labeled **fictional persona** for the demo. Suggested persona:

"Jordan R., age 16, fictional example used for teaching only."

How to run it

1. Before class, prepare (as slides, a mock browser screenshot, or a doc — not an actual live web search) a fictional search-results mockup for "Jordan R." showing: - A results list with 4–5 fictional entries: e.g., a GitHub profile with two projects (one with a good README, one abandoned/empty), a school club webpage mentioning them, an old social post, and a Lumexa project page.
2. Screen-share the mockup and narrate it as a stranger would read it: - *"If I'm a stranger looking at this, what do I conclude about Jordan? What looks strong? What looks unfinished or confusing?"*
3. Ask students to call out (chat or voice) which entries build trust and which ones create doubt.
4. Land the point: *"Notice we didn't judge Jordan as a person — we judged the evidence. That's the whole game: making sure the evidence that's visible is the evidence you'd choose."*

Never have students search their own names aloud or share personal search results with the class — this protects privacy and avoids putting anyone on the spot for gaps that aren't their fault (many students are simply too young to have a footprint yet).

Discussion Questions

1. "Before today, had you ever thought about what a stranger would find if they looked you up? What's your gut reaction to that idea?"
 2. "What's one project you've made — on Lumexa or elsewhere — that you think is genuinely good evidence of a skill, even if nobody's seen it yet?"
 3. "Where's the line between 'professional' and 'fake'? Can you think of an example of someone (a creator, a small business, anyone) who seems professional without seeming fake?"
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Common Misconceptions (and how to correct them)

Misconception	Correction
"I need real work experience already to have a professional identity."	Not true. A professional identity starts with <i>evidence of skill</i> , not a job history. A working project, a solved bug, a documented process — all count as evidence at 15–18.
"Professional = fake, corporate, and boring."	Reframe: professional means <i>clear and backed by evidence</i> , not stiff or impersonal. Their personality can and should show through.
"I don't have anything online yet, so I have no digital reputation."	Having little to no footprint is a neutral starting point, not a failure — it just means today is about starting on purpose instead of by accident.
"This is basically just making a resume."	A resume is a claim-based document. This course is about <i>evidence-based</i> identity — portfolios, live projects, and case studies, which is a different (and stronger) kind of proof.
"Building a professional identity means I'm trying to get a job / freelance right now."	Correct this directly: this course's sequence is Identity → Services → Clients → Professional Presence → Opportunities. Today is only step one — self-understanding, not job-seeking.

Likely Student Difficulties

- **Younger students (15) with no online footprint** may feel behind or discouraged. Have the "no footprint yet" alternative activity ready (see Student Lesson) and normalize it verbally before the activity begins.
- **Students who conflate "professional" with "adult/formal"** may write worksheet answers in a stiff, generic voice. Encourage them to write in their real voice — "professional" is about honesty and evidence, not tone.
- **Students who don't yet have 3 pieces of evidence** may struggle with that worksheet section. Prompt them: a half-finished project, a helpful comment/explanation they gave a classmate, a design they made in another class — anything real and specific counts.
- **Oversharing risk:** a few students may want to publicly discuss personal search results (their own name, social media, etc.) in the group. Redirect this to the private worksheet rather than open chat/voice, per the safe-activity design.

Troubleshooting & Classroom Management Notes

- If the live demo mockup isn't ready, do **not** improvise a real live search on stage — fall back to describing the persona verbally and sketching the "results" on a shared whiteboard/doc instead.
- If a student starts sharing personal identifying details (full name, school, social handles) in open chat during the activity, gently redirect: *"Let's keep that part private on your worksheet — you don't need to share it with the group."*
- If time runs short, the Activity segment (0:40–0:55) can be trimmed to 10 minutes and finished as take-home; the worksheet submission deadline should then be communicated clearly.
- Keep the tone conversational, not lecture-heavy — this lesson is discussion- and reflection-driven, not content-heavy.

How to Review Student Work

When reviewing submitted worksheets, check for: 1. **Specificity** — did they name real projects/skills, or write vague claims ("I'm good at coding")? Vague answers need a follow-up nudge before Lesson 2. 2. **Honesty** — flag (privately, kindly) anything that reads as exaggerated or unverifiable; this course is built on credibility, so this is worth correcting early and gently. 3. **At least 3 evidence items** — even informal or small ones are fine; the goal is the habit of pointing at evidence, not the scale of it. 4. **A genuine goal statement** — not a copy of the lesson's own language back at you.

Give brief, specific written feedback (1–2 sentences per student) rather than a grade — this is a foundational, reflective lesson, not a graded skills check.

How to Close the Lesson

1. Recap the three core ideas in one sentence each: *professional identity is what your evidence says about you; digital reputation is what's already out there; this course helps you make both intentional instead of accidental.*
2. Preview Lesson 2: *"Next lesson, we start turning what you wrote today into the beginning of an actual portfolio site."*
3. Confirm the exact submission method and deadline for the worksheet.
4. Thank students for being candid — self-reflection lessons work best when students trust it's a safe space, so acknowledge that explicitly before ending the call.